Intelligence. They began battling to limit virtually everything the administration was trying to do in Central America.

In early 1983, I wrote in my diary: “NSPG meeting re El Salvador: We must step up aid or we’re going to lose this one . . .” A few days later, another: “Tomorrow we start trying to convince Congress we must have more money for El Salvador. We have an entire plan for bolstering the government forces. This is one we must win.” After a meeting with several Republican and Democratic congressmen who had gone to El Salvador to learn what was going on there, I wrote: “Not all had been on our side before they went—they are now. The stories they told all added up to the fact that El Salvador is only the current battlefield. What is going on is a general revolution aimed at all of Central America and, yes, Mexico.” After a meeting about Central America with Bill Casey and Bill Clark in June, I wrote, “We’re losing if we don’t do something soon. Those in Congress who are dribbling out about one quarter of what we ask for and need could be playing politics. They’d like to give enough money to keep us in the game [while] El Salvador bleeds to death. Then they call it my plan and it lost Central America. We have to take this to the people and make them all see what’s going on. If the Soviets win in Central America, we lose in Geneva and every place else.”

The skirmishes I had with Congress in 1982 and 1983 were minor compared with those that would come later. My battles with Capitol Hill over Central America would continue through my entire presidency.

I never understood the depth of the emotional resistance among some members of Congress to helping the government of El Salvador. Well-intentioned or not, they were in effect furthering Moscow’s agenda in Latin America. The United States had begun sending arms and ammunition to help El Salvador resist Marxist guerrillas when Jimmy Carter was president. I decided we should continue it. Yes, it